The Wrong Room

Where 1,000 indie founders are building vs where the money actually is.

A forensic read of **1,000 live startups** — self-reported revenue, frozen 30 Jul 2026. Not a survey of intentions. Not a pitch deck. A snapshot of what is actually earning.

The findings are uncomfortable. Most founders are in the wrong category, at the wrong price, selling to the wrong customer. The data shows exactly where the money is sitting — and who is not in that room.

$13.5M

total MRR in pool

n = 1,000

live startups in sample

30 Jul 2026

data frozen

FINDING 01

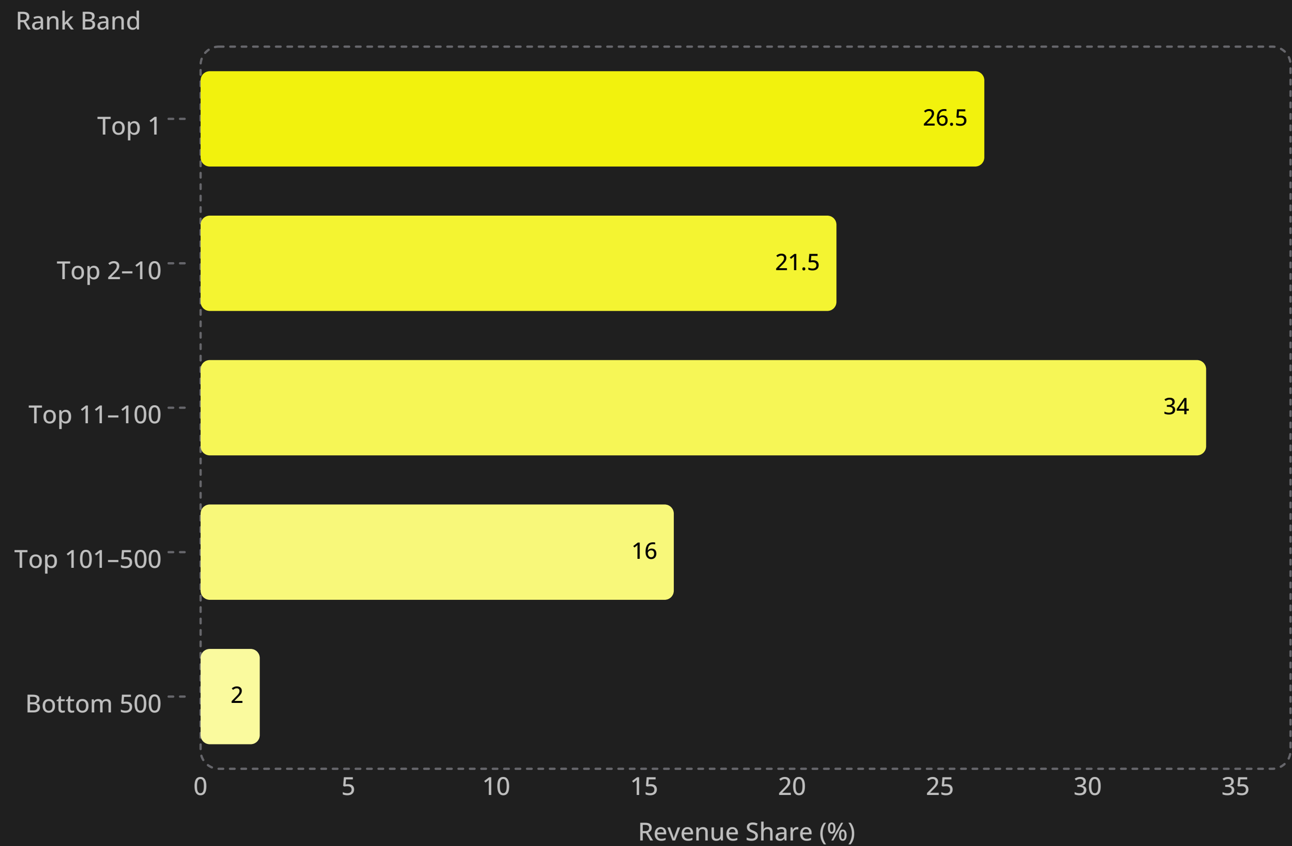
Most of this market doesn't exist

26.5%

of all revenue, one company.

Top 10 hold **48%**. Top 100 hold **82%**. Bottom 500 hold **0.2%**.

Median startup earns **$282/month**. 20% earn nothing at all.

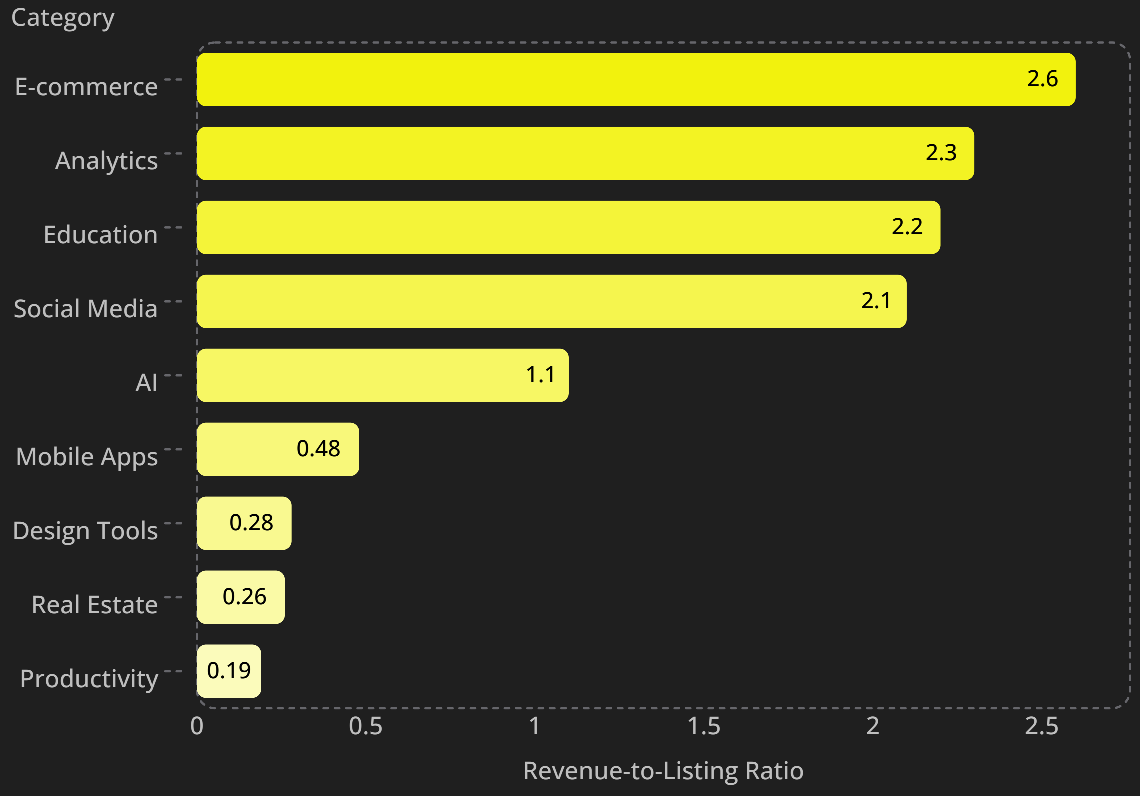


Revenue concentration decay. The long tail is not a market — it is a waiting room.

> "This is not a lottery you enter. It is a positioning problem you solve."

FINDING 02

Attention and revenue are in different rooms



Ratio above 1.0 = more revenue than listings. Below 1.0 = more builders than dollars.

Overweight categories

E-comm **2.6x** · Analytics **2.3x** · Education **2.2x** · Social Media **2.1x**

Revenue exceeds listing share. Fewer builders, more money per entrant.

Underweight categories

Productivity **0.19x** · Real Estate **0.26x** · Design Tools **0.28x** · Mobile Apps **0.48x**

49 Productivity builders share 1% of the money.

AI: a fair bet, not a great one

27% of listings · 31% of revenue · ratio **1.1x**

Not a bad bet. A fair bet with the most competitors.

> "Productivity has 49 builders sharing 1% of the money. That is the definition of a crowded, wrong room."

FINDING 03

The customer decision is worth more than the product decision

5.7×

B2B median MRR vs B2C median MRR

$1,036 B2B median MRR

$181 B2C median MRR

Revenue per subscriber

$83 B2B vs $13 B2C

Same product category. Six times the per-seat yield.

Crossing $10k MRR

25% of B2B clear $10k MRR. Only 16% of B2C do.

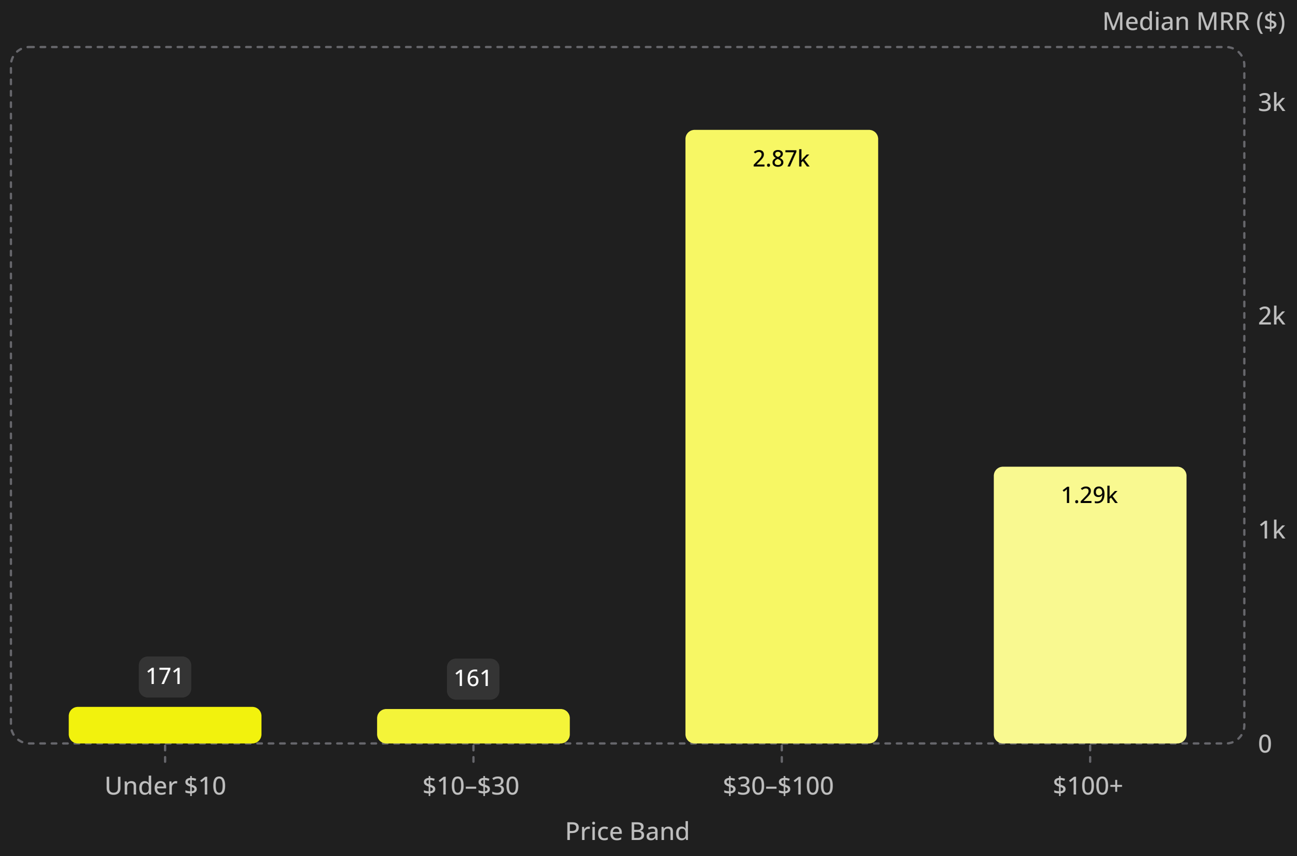
The ceiling is higher and the floor is higher.

The build effort is identical. The customer selection is not. Most founders never make this choice consciously — they default to building for people like themselves, which usually means consumers.

> "Same build effort. Six times the outcome. Most founders never make this choice consciously."

FINDING 04

There is a cliff at $30 and almost nobody crosses it



The $30–$100 band is the signal. Everything below it is noise at scale.

Under $10

$171 median MRR. Half of all startups with a published price start here.

$10 to $30

$161 median MRR. Marginally worse than under $10. The "safe middle" is a trap.

$30 to $100

$2,869 median MRR. The cliff. 17x jump from the band below.

$100+

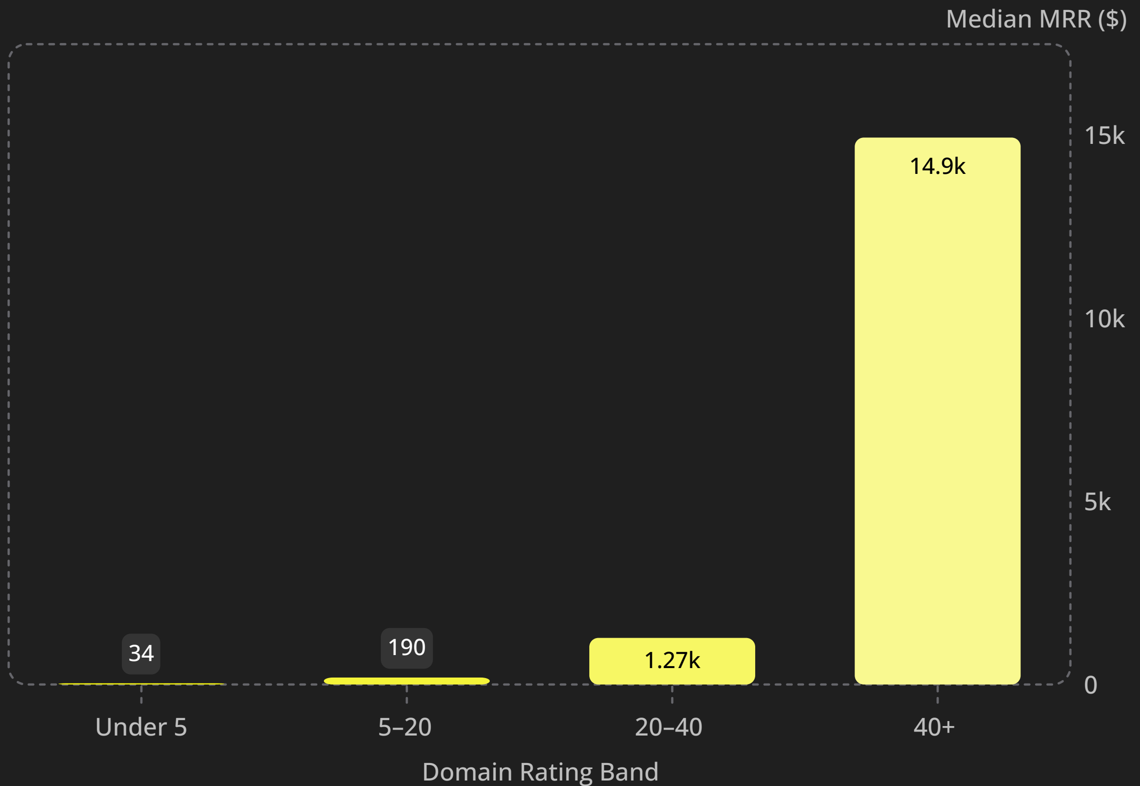
$1,294 median MRR. Strong, but lower than $30–$100. Enterprise complexity compresses the median.

Usage/credit-based pricing earns $66 per subscriber. Freemium earns $19.

> "Below $30 you are not cheaper, you are invisible. Price is a positioning signal, not a conversion lever."

FINDING 05

An audience rents you attention. A domain owns it.



Domain authority compounds. Social following does not.

0.18

X followers correlation

Correlation coefficient vs revenue. Weak signal, high noise.

0.48

Domain authority correlation

Nearly 3× stronger predictor of revenue than social following.

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307 startups have **zero X followers** and a median MRR of **$214** — roughly the same as everyone else. The audience is not the asset. The domain is.

DR 40+ earns **$14,933 median MRR**. DR under 5 earns $34. That is a 439× gap driven entirely by compounding organic authority.

> "An audience rents you attention. A domain owns it. Only one of these compounds."

FINDING 06

Build anywhere. Sell to the US.

56%

of total revenue from US-based startups

US is **34%** of listings but **56%** of revenue. The revenue-to-listing ratio is **1.65×**.

Singapore — $2,126 median MRR

Highest median of any geography. Small sample, but directionally consistent: founders selling to Western enterprise buyers.

US — $1,263 median MRR

34% of listings, 56% of revenue. The default market for a reason.

Netherlands — $1,022 · Canada — $919

Strong performers. Both sell primarily to US and English-speaking markets.

India — $6 median MRR

59 startups. 41% earn zero. But Supergrow ($79k) and Web3Forms ($33k) sell almost entirely to Western buyers. The building is fine. The customer selection is not.

> "India's problem is not building capacity. It is customer selection."

FINDING 07

Distribution and revenue are cheaper to buy than to build

262

of 1,000 startups are for sale right now.

Median asking price: **$35,000**

Median valuation: **3.2× ARR**

Listed vs unlisted MRR

Businesses for sale have a median MRR of **$1,055** vs **$187** for the rest. You are not buying a failing product — you are buying proven distribution at 3.2× ARR.

The Mobile Apps red flag

56% of all Mobile Apps in the dataset are for sale — the highest of any category. This is not a bargain bin. It is a churn signal. Founders are exiting a category with structural monetization problems.

The acquisition thesis

At $35k median ask, a buyer acquires $1,055/month in MRR — a 33-month payback at face value, often faster with repositioning. The build-from-zero alternative costs the same in time and has a median outcome of $282/month.

> "Distribution and revenue are cheaper to buy than to build."

VERDICT

If I were building today

Five decisions. Each one is supported by the data above. Together they define the room where the money actually is.

01

Sell to businesses, not consumers.

$1,036 vs $181 median MRR. The product decision is secondary to the customer decision.

02

Pick Marketing, Analytics or Education — not Productivity or Mobile.

Revenue-to-listing ratios of 2.1–2.3× vs 0.19–0.48×. Category selection is leverage.

03

Price the entry tier above $30, usage-based where possible.

$2,869 median MRR in the $30–$100 band. Below $30 you are invisible, not affordable.

04

Own a domain and rank on it. Ignore follower count.

DR 40+ earns $14,933 median MRR. X follower correlation with revenue: 0.18. Domain correlation: 0.48.

05

Sell in USD to US buyers.

US is 34% of listings and 56% of revenue. Geography is a pricing and positioning decision.

B2B above $30

$2,637 median MRR

B2C under $30

$138 median MRR

The same 12 months of work. **19× apart.** The gap is not talent. It is not timing. It is five decisions most founders make by default rather than by design.

METHODOLOGY

Three caveats an analyst should say out loud

The findings above are directionally strong. They are not a controlled experiment. Before you act on them, hold these three constraints in mind.

1	2	3
Survivorship bias in the revenue signal Revenue is self-reported and connected voluntarily. Winners connect. Quitters do not. The $282 median MRR is almost certainly an overstatement of the true population median — the failures are not in the file.	**This is a survivor sample** The 1,000 startups in this dataset are the ones still alive and listed on 30 Jul 2026. Every startup that shut down, pivoted, or simply stopped updating its listing is invisible here. The data tells you what works among survivors, not what works in general.	**Small-country samples are directional only** Singapore, Estonia and Netherlands have fewer than 15 startups each. The median MRR figures for these geographies are directional signals, not statistically conclusive findings. Do not over-index on small-n country data.

> "The data tells you where money is sitting. It does not tell you why nobody has taken it yet. That part is still your job."